WEEK 11 / COMMUNITIES, CREATIVITY, AND PLAYER CULTURE

Competitive Gaming, Streaming, and Content Creation

The rise of competitive gaming and multiplayer communities as well as exploring streaming culture and video content creation.

This week, we examine the rise of competitive gaming and multiplayer communities, as well as exploring streaming culture and video content creation. We will discuss how these elements have transformed the gaming experience and fostered new forms of social interaction.

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23 RESOURCES / 3 TOPICS

TOPIC 01

Competitive Gaming and Esports

REQUIRED

Redeye at The International 8: An excerpt from This is esports (and How to Spell it)

BOOK EXCERPT | ~9 MIN

https://www.shacknews.com/article/118403/redeye-at-the-international-8-an-excerpt-from-this-is-esports-and-how-to-spell-it

This excerpt from Paul 'Redeye' Chaloner's (hard Ch) book chronicles the remarkable evolution of esports, particularly through the lens of The International 8 (TI8), a major Dota 2 tournament. Redeye emphasizes the transition from humble beginnings to a global phenomenon with massive live audiences (17,000 daily at TI8), international teams, and immense financial backing. He points out that esports has achieved this success by remaining authentic to the games themselves, rather than conforming to traditional television formats. The narrative highlights the high stakes, professionalization, and significant prize money in esports, citing the $25 million prize pot at TI8 (with over $10 million for the winning team) and the fact that 83 esports athletes had earned over a million dollars in prize money by early 2020. A link to the full book is in additional resources.

Some Highlights:

Esports has rapidly escalated into a global spectacle, attracting millions of unique viewers for major tournaments, such as the League of Legends World Championship in 2018, which garnered 76 million unique viewers worldwide.
The industry is characterized by its high commercial value and professionalization, demonstrated by substantial brand sponsorships (e.g., Amazon, Audi, Coca-Cola) and enormous prize pools, with TI8 alone offering $25 million.
- Esports has achieved its current level of success by maintaining its authenticity and not compromising game formats for traditional TV. Its growth is fueled by a passionate audience of gamers who enjoy both playing and watching top-level competition, connected globally by the internet.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

The Biggest Cheating Scandals in Minecraft Speedrunning

YOUTUBE | ~30 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pGOryDTE9dY&ab_channel=MarcusFireworks

This video delves into notable cheating scandals within the competitive Minecraft speedrunning community, illustrating how the pursuit of world records and competitive advantage can lead to illicit shortcuts. It details the cases of three prominent speedrunners: Dream, who was caught manipulating game code to artificially increase his luck with item drops; Flowbee, who confessed to splicing video footage and making in-game decisions indicative of prior knowledge of the game seed; and Minecravenger, who was found to have cheated for years through methods like using save states, manipulating dragon mechanics, and altering loot generation. The video underscores the community's rigorous verification processes and the severe reputational consequences for cheaters, concluding that while cheating persists, these incidents serve to educate new players about the importance of integrity.

Highlights:

The competitive nature of speedrunning, driven by the desire for world records and recognition, creates a temptation for players to cheat, employing tactics like game footage splicing, code manipulation, or exploiting game mechanics.
The Minecraft speedrunning community, through its moderation teams and attentive top players, employs sophisticated analysis and statistical methods to detect cheating, as demonstrated by the detailed expose of Dream's statistically improbable item drops.
- Motivations for cheating can include gaining credibility, recognition, and financial benefits through building a public brand, as revealed by Flowbee's confession. Such actions carry significant reputational risks and consequences within the gaming community.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

Ecstasy of Order: The Tetris Masters

DOCUMENTARY | ~93 MIN

https://tubitv.com/movies/652019/ecstasy-of-order-the-tetris-masters

A 2011 documentary that follows top record-holding Tetris players as they prepare for the inaugural Classic Tetris World Championship in Los Angeles.

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REQUIRED

The Biggest Lie in Video Game History : The Billy Mitchell Story

YOUTUBE | ~232 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PySD_FiEl5c

This comprehensive collection of source material critically examines the long-standing controversy surrounding Billy Mitchell's video game world records, particularly for Donkey Kong and Pac-Man. It presents detailed analysis disputing the legitimacy of his high scores, focusing on technical evidence that suggests his famous recordings were produced on MAME emulation rather than original arcade hardware. The video further explores witness testimonies, legal proceedings, and Mitchell's various defenses, scrutinizing their credibility and highlighting inconsistencies in his narrative over time. Ultimately, the sources aim to uncover the truth behind claims of deception and fabrication in competitive gaming history.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.
LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

This Is Esports (And How to Spell It)

BOOK

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/1i25tbk/alma991020341249708681

Book Description: Pro gaming's award-winning broadcaster Paul Redeye Chaloner brings us the definitive book on esports, the fastest growing entertainment phenomenon in the world today. This is the full book that our first article was excerpted from.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Reality is Broken

BOOK

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/2sp9f6/alma991003647129708681

Book Description: Visionary game designer Jane McGonigal shows how we can harness the power of computer games to solve real-world problems and boost global happiness, since her research suggests that gamers are expert problem solvers and collaborators because they regularly cooperate with other players to overcome daunting virtual challenges.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

This Gaming Life: Travels in Three Cities

BOOK

https://muse.jhu.edu/book/52295/pdf/download

Book Description: A look at what it's like to play video games, their cultures in three different international cities, and their significance in everyday life.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Arena

BOOK

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/1m5ko1o/alma991036931049708681

Book Description from publisher: A fast-paced and gripping near-future science fiction debut about the gritty world of competitive gaming ... Every week, Kali Ling fights to the death on national TV. She's died hundreds of times. And it never gets easier ... The RAGE tournaments--the Virtual Gaming League's elite competition where the best gamers in the world compete in a no-holds-barred fight to the digital death. Every bloody kill is broadcast to millions. Every player is a modern gladiator--leading a life of ultimate fame, responsible only for entertaining the masses. And though their weapons and armor are digital, the pain is real. Chosen to be the first female captain in RAGE tournament history, Kali Ling is at the top of the world--until one of her teammates overdoses. Now, she must confront the truth about the tournament. Because it is much more than a game--and even in the real world, not everything is as it seems. The VGL hides dark secrets. And the only way to change the rules is to fight from the inside.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Players

PARAMOUNT+ SERIES, NOW ON APPLE TV+

https://tv.apple.com/us/show/players/umc.cmc.75z3rptet3l4iartn52dmjsb4

Description: To win the championship, a professional "League of Legends" team needs their young rookie and their veteran to put their egos aside and work together to prove themselves on the world stage.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

1UP

AMAZON PRIME MOVIE

https://www.amazon.com/gp/video/detail/amzn1.dv.gti.c2a1ec07-6c42-4647-b638-e5bc4ea39e26?autoplay=0&ref_=atv_cf_strg_wb

Description: Valerie is a competitive gamer whose impressive skills have landed her a place on her university's male-dominated esports team. Told she'll never be a starting player, Valerie forms an all-girl team to take down the guys at the national championship.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Falling Into Your Smile

NETFLIX TV SERIES

https://www.netflix.com/title/81566868?source=35&fromWatch=true

Description: After joining an all-male e-sports team, an amateur gamer tests her skills and leads her team to the world championships. Based on a novel. Mandarin audio with English subtitles.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

The International (Dota 2)

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nJsAbXQ7DG0&ab_channel=NoobFromUA

Find and watch eSports event footage, e.g., The International (Dota 2) or the Esports World Cup.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Esports World Cup

LIVE STREAM

https://esportsworldcup.com/en/watch/

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

League of Legends World Championship

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jWjrdz-lLdU&ab_channel=LoLEsports

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Esports World Cup: Level Up

DOCUMENTARY TV SERIES

https://esportsworldcup.com/en/levelup

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Twin Galaxies

WEBSITE

https://www.twingalaxies.com/

Twin Galaxies is a social media platform and video game database. Twin Galaxies is the official supplier of video game records to Guinness World Records.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Speedrun.com

WEBSITE

http://speedrun.com

Speedrun.com is the premier resource for speedrunning information, with a community-driven leaderboard, extensive database of games and categories, and active forums for discussion and support.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Esports Insider

WEBSITE

https://esportsinsider.com/

A news site all about esports. Please note that this site includes news and advertisements related to esports betting - I am not endorsing such activity.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

TOPIC 02

Multiplayer Communities

REQUIRED

Dear Parents, This is Why You SHOULD Let Kids Play Video Games!

TED TALK | ~9 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OHX26iN85kM&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

Avery Eun's TEDx talk challenges common parental concerns about video games by highlighting the positive impacts of competitive esports and gaming communities. They share personal anecdotes, explaining how video games like Minecraft and Overwatch helped them maintain friendships across geographical distances and bond with new peers after moving to California. Eun emphasizes that video games, contrary to popular belief, promote strong relationships and social connections. They also detail the inclusive and diverse nature of the gaming community, contrasting it with traditional sports by showcasing examples like professional female Overwatch player Geguri (ge gur ee) who competes alongside men based solely on skill. Eun concludes by arguing that competitive video games demand significant practice, talent, and communication skills, similar to physical sports, and highlights the booming growth and commercialization of esports.

Some Highlights:

Video games, particularly online multiplayer games, are highly social. Surveys show 83% of American teen gamers play with friends in the same room, 76% play with friends online, and 36% make new friends while gaming. Discord, an app for the gaming community, had 115 million registered users and processed 530 million daily messages in August 2018.
In 2018, the League of Legends World Championship had a peak viewership of over 200 million viewers, while the Super Bowl in the same year had a little over 100 million viewers.

The gaming community is incredibly inclusive and diverse, transcending age, gender, nationality, and geographical barriers. This stands in contrast to traditional sports communities, which are often divided. Competitive video games require intensive practice, talent, focus, and communication skills, similar to traditional physical sports like soccer or volleyball. Esports has seen explosive growth, with over 120 universities having collegiate esports programs and major brands like Nike signing sponsorship deals with professional leagues.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

Benefits of multiplayer games: what the research shows

BLOG POST | ~12 MIN

https://guul.games/blog/embracing-the-social-side-benefits-of-multiplayer-online-gaming-with-friends

This post explores scientific evidence regarding the social, cognitive, and emotional advantages of playing multiplayer games. It systematically categorizes research findings to show how collaborative gaming fosters meaningful social capital and strengthens interpersonal bonds rather than isolating players from reality. Furthermore, the source highlights that these benefits-ranging from improved strategic problem-solving to enhanced mood regulation-are most effective when participation is voluntary and consistent. Ultimately, the article serves to bridge the gap between casual entertainment and professional team-building by demonstrating how structured digital play can positively impact individual well-being and community cohesion. This is a great source to find and explore the research further.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 5: Students will gain insights into how technologies like artificial intelligence, virtual reality, and online connectivity shape gaming experiences.

REQUIRED

The Pros and Cons of Online Competitive Gaming: An Evidence-Based Approach to Assessing Young Players' Well-Being

RESEARCH REPORT | ~22 MIN

https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/psychology/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.651530/full

This research paper explores the health and well-being outcomes associated with competitive online gaming and esports among young people aged 12-24 in Australia. The study's findings suggest that moderated gaming engagement is preferable for health. It identifies that heavy/frequent gamers exhibit more harmful outcomes, such as increased sedentary time, higher consumption of soft drinks and alcohol, higher rates of smoking, and more sleep difficulties, compared to light/casual gamers and non-gamers. Conversely, light/casual gamers reported similar health and well-being to non-gamers. The research also highlights the effectiveness of parental strategies, like setting time limits and encouraging physical activity, in mitigating negative gaming behaviors in minors.

Highlights:

Heavy/frequent online competitive gaming is linked to various adverse well-being outcomes in young people, including increased sedentary time (up to 3.84 hours on weekends for minors), higher soft drink consumption, increased harmful drinking among young adults, higher smoking incidence, and more frequent sleep troubles for minors.
Casual/light gamers show similar health and well-being outcomes to non-gamers, suggesting that gaming in moderation does not necessarily lead to negative health impacts. Some research indicates competitive gaming

can even enhance cognitive abilities and decision-making when balanced with physical activity.
- Parental mitigation strategies are effective in influencing minors' gaming habits and health behaviors. For instance, parents setting time limits was associated with reduced weekday gaming hours, and encouraging physical activity led to more active days for children.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

TOPIC 03

Streaming and Content Creation

REQUIRED

The Rise of Video Game Streaming: A New Era of Entertainment

BLOG POST | ~4 MIN

https://medium.com/@cook.benjamin/the-rise-of-video-game-streaming-a-new-era-of-entertainment-591ea50e0d6c

This article examines the explosive growth of video game streaming, driven by platforms like Twitch and YouTube Gaming, as a transformative force in the entertainment industry. It highlights the live, interactive nature of streaming, which cultivates a strong sense of community and engagement between streamers and their viewers. The rise of streaming has led to a new class of professional gamers who monetize their passion through sponsorships, donations, and ad revenue, achieving celebrity status comparable to traditional entertainers. The article also details the broad benefits for both players (showcasing skills, brand building, income) and viewers (discovering games, learning strategies, entertainment). Furthermore, streaming has significantly impacted the gaming industry by creating new marketing avenues and providing crucial exposure for indie game developers. The future of streaming is envisioned with further accessibility through cloud gaming and enhanced immersion via VR/AR technologies.

Highlights:

Video game streaming provides a highly interactive and social experience, enabling real-time communication between players and audiences, which fosters a global community united by a shared passion for gaming.
The platform has created a new class of professional gamers who earn a living from streaming, gaining celebrity status and substantial fan followings by showcasing their skills and entertaining a global audience.
- Streaming has a profound impact on the gaming industry, revolutionizing game marketing through influencer partnerships and offering a vital platform for indie game developers to gain exposure and reach a wider audience without large marketing budgets.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Twitch

STREAMING PLATFORM

https://www.twitch.tv/

Find and watch video game streams and/or on-demand content on YouTube, Twitch, or other streaming / video on-demand platforms

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.